WRITING SAMPLE · POLICY ANALYSIS & PROGRAM EVALUATION

# Factors Contributing to Improved Safety Outcomes

An analysis of the legislative, policy, practice and workforce changes associated with declining maltreatment recurrence between FFY 2019–2020 and FFY 2021–2022.


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## Introduction

The purpose of this memorandum is to analyze the potential factors that may have contributed to the improvement in safety outcomes, and to identify areas for further enhancement in the agency's Performance Improvement Plan.

Between FFY 2019–2020 and FFY 2021–2022 there was a notable drop in the recurrence of maltreatment, from 12.8 to 11.0, and a decrease in repeat maltreatment, from 14.88 to 10.49. This improvement in safety outcomes prompts the need to investigate the contributing factors during that timeframe.

## Analysis

### Legislative context

#### Family First Prevention Services Act (2018) — federal

Indiana has been working to implement the provisions of the Family First Prevention Services Act, which became law at the federal level in 2018. This legislation prioritizes family-based services to prevent children from entering foster care and promotes kinship care and other supportive services (Bipartisan Budget Act of 2018).

#### Senate Enrolled Act 1 (2019) — Indiana

This legislation made significant changes to DCS, including provisions related to case management, foster care and child protection. It aimed to improve outcomes for children in the child welfare system and enhance accountability within the agency.

#### Senate Bill 398 (2019) — Indiana

This legislation mandates that DCS collaborate with adoptive parents of children with special needs who qualify for an adoption subsidy, and allocate necessary funds to the adoption assistance account to permit payment of adoption subsidies. DCS is prohibited from terminating an adoption subsidy agreement with adoptive parents due to insufficient funds in the adoption assistance account.

### Policy context

#### 4.03 Conducting the Assessment — Overview (v10)

This policy, effective 1 July 2019 to 31 July 2022, was updated in response to the 2019 legislation. It now includes details about conducting subsequent safety assessments as part of the Assessment Staffing Guide, and revisions made by the initial safety workgroup.

#### 4.18 Establishing Initial Child Safety (v7)

This policy, effective 1 March 2019 to 28 February 2022, was updated and renamed "Establishing Initial Child Safety." It incorporates relevant information from policy 4.41 Safety Staffing, which was archived, and from policy 4.37 Change in Household Composition, also set for archival.

#### 4.22 Making an Assessment Finding (v10, v11, v12)

This policy underwent several revisions to ensure that the Assessment Staffing Guide is completed for all assessments. The versions were effective as follows: v10 from 1 January 2019 to 28 February 2019; v11 from 1 March 2019 to 31 August 2020; and v12 from 1 September 2020 to 31 December 2021.

#### DCS 20-01 Temporary Modification to Foster Care Licensing Requirements (15 April 2020 – 7 March 2022)

This policy provided temporary exceptions to select foster family home licensing policies due to the Indiana public health emergency. These exceptions expired with the expiration of the public health emergency unless otherwise extended or terminated by DCS; the policy was terminated on 7 March 2022. By providing temporary exception to foster family home licensing policies, it may have allowed more flexibility in foster care placements, potentially leading to more stable environments for children.

#### DCS 20-02 Title IV-E State Plan Amendment for Administrative Law Judges (1 July 2020)

This policy states that, effective on the date DCS Administrative Law Judges move to the Office of Administrative Law Proceedings, DCS will send requests for an Administrative Appeal Hearing to that office. The transfer may have led to more efficient and impartial hearings, possibly resulting in better outcomes for children.

#### DCS-21-01 Residential Treatment Changes (1 March 2021)

This policy states that during the Child and Family Team Review, if placement for residential treatment is appropriate, a Residential Treatment Facility Search will be completed to assist with determining the appropriate placement of the child, and a step-down plan will be completed. Implementation of the facility search and step-down plan may have ensured children were placed in the most appropriate residential treatment settings, potentially reducing the likelihood of maltreatment recurrence.

#### HR-3-8 Worker Safety (v3)

This policy, effective 1 April 2021 to 31 October 2021, was updated to align with current standards and requirements for ensuring the safety of staff. It now includes information on psychological safety, universal precautions and the use of the agency's staff safety application.

#### DCS-21-05 Safe Assessment Closure Team (12 April 2021 – 1 March 2022)

This policy establishes the Safe Assessment Closure Team (SafeACT) to remove barriers to timely closure for specific assessments of child abuse and/or neglect.

#### DCS-21-11 Rate increases for home-based service providers (1 March 2021)

This policy states that DCS allocates $10 million each fiscal year for the exclusive purpose of providing rate increases to DCS-contracted providers of home-based services. By providing rate increases, the policy may have improved the quality and availability of these services, potentially contributing to a reduction in maltreatment recurrence.

#### DCS-21-06 Assessment Staffing Guide (12 April 2021)

This policy introduced the Assessment Staffing Guide, which replaces the safety staffing form previously used for every assessment, including those deemed "safe." The change may have improved the assessment process, potentially leading to more accurate and effective interventions to prevent maltreatment.

#### DCS-21-15 Continuation of Collaborative Care services (1 October 2021)

Due to the public health emergency, the agency director authorized the continuation of Collaborative Care services for youth who wished to remain in the program. This may have provided additional support and stability, potentially providing safer support for older youth.

#### DCS-21-17 "Just Stop It" documentation reductions (15 October 2021 – 31 January 2023)

Under this administrative letter, Family Case Managers are no longer required to document the visitation plan under Plans and Tools, to upload the face-to-face contact form, or to use the confirmation notice of a Child and Family Team Meeting form. By simplifying documentation requirements, the policy may have allowed Family Case Managers to spend more time on direct service provision, potentially leading to better outcomes for children.

#### DCS-21-18 Family Case Manager schedule flexibility (8 November 2021 – 7 November 2022)

This policy was introduced to balance the needs of the families the agency serves directly with the work-life balance and well-being of Family Case Managers, by setting out the flexibility available to them. Greater flexibility may have improved job satisfaction and retention, potentially leading to more consistent and effective service provision.

#### New employee sign-on bonus of $1,500 (29 November 2021)

This policy states that a $1,500 sign-on bonus will be awarded to any staff member working full time who begins employment as a Family Case Manager between 29 November 2021 and 30 June 2022. This incentive may have attracted more qualified and dedicated individuals to the role, potentially improving the quality of services and reducing the likelihood of maltreatment recurrence.

#### DCS-21-20 Child-focused Child and Family Team meetings (21 December 2021)

This policy states that DCS will make concerted efforts to actively engage the child's parent, guardian or custodian and discuss with them the benefits of having the child's placement provider present at the Child and Family Team Meeting. Actively engaging parents in this way may have improved communication and collaboration, potentially leading to better outcomes for children.

#### Referral bonuses (7 March 2022)

This policy states that a referring employee will receive a referral bonus for each referred candidate if the noted conditions are met: $500 for a full-time referral, $250 for a part-time referral and $100 for an intermittent position. This may have incentivized employees to refer qualified candidates, potentially improving the quality of services and reducing the recurrence of maltreatment.

#### DCS-22-1 Intercounty courtesy requests (9 August 2022)

This policy states that a courtesy interview may be requested when the interview subject or child's home is one or more hours away from the requesting local office. This may have improved the efficiency and effectiveness of investigations, potentially reducing the likelihood of maltreatment recurrence.

#### DCS-22-2 Intercounty transfer of assessment (9 August 2022)

This policy states that decisions to transfer an assessment are at the discretion of the Family Case Manager Supervisor or office designee in the office to which the assessment was assigned; transfer is not mandatory. Discretionary transfer may have ensured that cases were handled by the most appropriate and capable staff, potentially leading to better outcomes for children.

#### DCS-22-3 Exception to degree requirement for Family Case Manager positions (6 September 2022)

This policy states that when a viable candidate who does not possess a bachelor's degree is considered for a Family Case Manager position, an exception to the degree requirement may be made. This may have expanded the pool of potential candidates, potentially leading to a more diverse and effective workforce.

### Practice context

#### Trauma-informed care initiatives

There has been a growing emphasis on trauma-informed care within DCS, including training for staff and service providers on recognizing and responding to the effects of trauma on children and families involved with the agency.

#### Family preservation services

DCS has been expanding prevention and early intervention programs aimed at addressing risk factors and providing support to families before child maltreatment occurs. These family preservation programs include home visiting services, parent education programs and community-based initiatives.

## Safe Assessment Closure Team (SafeACT)

### Background

SafeACT, launched in 2021, may have played a pivotal role in improving safety outcomes. Program leadership highlighted several initiatives and improvements implemented since the launch, including adjustments to the Assessment Staffing Guide, quality assurance processes, feedback mechanisms, and policy updates regarding assessment documentation. While official reports directly linking SafeACT to safety outcomes are limited, program leadership emphasized the rapidity with which the team can effect statewide change and its role in providing consistent tools and communication channels.

### Background check policies and protocols

SafeACT has been involved in implementing background check policies for assessments. This indicates a proactive approach to ensuring the safety and well-being of children by enhancing the screening process for individuals involved in child welfare assessments.

### Thirty-day contacts and protocol enhancements

The implementation of 30-day contacts and protocol enhancement underscores the team's commitment to timely and thorough follow-up in child welfare cases. This proactive approach can help prevent recurrence and ensure ongoing support for at-risk children and families.

### Pediatric and domestic violence protocols

The integration of protocols related to pediatric referrals and domestic violence highlights the team's comprehensive approach to addressing various risk factors and vulnerabilities within families. By incorporating specialized protocols, SafeACT demonstrates an adaptive response to the diverse needs of the populations it serves.

### Adjustments to the Assessment Staffing Guide

The Assessment Staffing Guide serves as the backbone of documentation for the SafeACT team, providing a consistent framework for assessing and staffing cases. Adjustments made through an improvement project reflect a commitment to continuous improvement

and standardization of assessment practices, ensuring a common lens through which assessments are evaluated.

### Quality assurance processes

SafeACT has established robust quality assurance processes, including monthly reviews of calls and random pulls involving multiple agency teams. These measures ensure alignment and realignment of practices, and facilitate ongoing learning and improvement within the organization.

### Feedback mechanisms and communication channels

The streamlined feedback process and clear communication channels between SafeACT and local offices enhance overall safety by promoting consistency and collaboration. By providing timely feedback and data during meetings and virtual feedback sessions, the team facilitates continuous learning and knowledge sharing among involved parties.

### Reporting and data analysis

SafeACT generates weekly reports for leadership and central office staff, along with monthly data reports for internal review. This regular reporting mechanism enables informed decision-making and performance monitoring, ensuring accountability and transparency in operations.

### Overall results

Taken together, these elements underscore the multifaceted approach SafeACT has taken to improve safety outcomes within the child welfare system. Through policy implementation, protocol enhancement, standardized practices and robust quality assurance processes, the team demonstrates a proactive and data-driven approach to safeguarding children and families. These initiatives serve as critical components in understanding the factors contributing to improved safety outcomes and provide valuable insights for future strategies within the agency.

## Conclusion

The analysis presented highlights a multifaceted approach taken by various stakeholders within DCS to improve safety outcomes. Through legislative reform, policy updates, practice enhancements and workforce initiatives, significant progress has been made in reducing maltreatment recurrence and enhancing child protection measures.

The implementation of legislative acts such as the Family First Prevention Services Act, and state-level initiatives including Senate Enrolled Act 1 and Senate Bill 398, has laid the groundwork for prioritizing family-based services, enhancing case management and improving outcomes for children in the child welfare system. These legislative changes

have been complemented by updates to policies and procedures, ensuring compliance with new regulations and streamlining assessment processes.

Furthermore, the introduction of trauma-informed care initiatives, family preservation services and the establishment of SafeACT has provided crucial support mechanisms for at-risk families and improved risk assessment practices. Incentive programs aimed at enhancing workforce satisfaction and attracting qualified individuals have also contributed to a more effective and dedicated workforce.

## Recommendations for practice

#### Continuous monitoring and evaluation

Implement a robust system for monitoring and evaluating the effectiveness of policies and initiatives. Regular data analysis and feedback mechanisms should be used to track progress and identify areas for improvement.

#### Training and capacity building

Prioritize ongoing training programs for staff and service providers to ensure they possess the skills and knowledge needed to address the complex needs of families and children involved with the agency.

#### Community engagement

Strengthen partnerships with community stakeholders, including local organizations, schools and healthcare providers, to leverage resources and support families in need. Engage in collaborative efforts to address systemic issues and promote community resilience.

#### Equity and inclusion

Ensure that policies and practices promote equity and inclusivity, particularly in recruitment, service provision and decision-making. Implement culturally responsive approaches to better serve diverse populations and address disparities in outcomes.

#### Sustainability and long-term planning

Develop sustainable strategies and long-term plans to maintain and further improve safety outcomes. Invest in preventative measures, early intervention programs and support services to address the root causes of maltreatment and promote child well-being.

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